

Lab: Mapping Your Circle's Boundaries

Group Activity — Systems

Objective

Work together as a circle to map the system boundaries of your own group, identifying internal states, external states, and the Markov blanket that separates them.

Materials

- Large sheet of paper or poster board
- Markers in three colors (one for internal, one for external, one for boundary)
- Sticky notes
- Your current crochet projects (to work on during discussion)

Duration

45-60 minutes

Setup

Gather your circle around a table with the large paper in the center. Choose three marker colors and assign them: one for internal states, one for external states, and one for blanket states.

Activity Steps

Step 1: Draw the Boundary (10 minutes)

As a group, draw a large circle (or oval) on the paper. This represents the Markov blanket of your crochet circle. Discuss as you draw: - What defines who is "in" the circle? Is it attendance? An invitation? Just showing up? - Is the boundary sharp or fuzzy? (It is almost

certainly fuzzy — that is fine. Mark the fuzzy zones.) - Where does the boundary sit physically? (The meeting space? The group chat? The shared pattern library?)

Step 2: Map Internal States (10 minutes)

Using sticky notes and the "internal" color marker, identify and place inside the circle everything that belongs to the group's internal states: - Shared knowledge and memories ("the time we all tried granny squares") - Ongoing projects and group challenges - Social bonds, inside jokes, shared vocabulary - Group norms and unwritten rules - Collective skills the group has developed together

Each person should contribute at least two sticky notes. Read them aloud as you place them.

Step 3: Map External States (10 minutes)

Using the "external" color, identify and place outside the circle: - The wider crafting community - Local yarn shops, craft stores, online retailers - Online crochet communities, social media, YouTube - Each member's life outside the circle - Broader cultural trends in crafting

Step 4: Map Blanket States (10 minutes)

Using the "boundary" color, identify and place on the circle's edge the mechanisms through which inside and outside interact: - Sensory states: How does outside information reach the group? (Members bring patterns, share social media finds, report on yarn shop visits) - Active states: How does the group influence the outside world? (Teaching friends, selling at craft fairs, posting online, requesting items from yarn shops) - Physical mediators: The meeting space, the group chat, shared digital folders

Step 5: Discussion (10-15 minutes)

While continuing to stitch, discuss as a group: 1. Were there items that were hard to classify? Why? 2. Look at the boundary — is it thick or thin? What does that say about how open or closed your circle is? 3. Imagine a new person joining next week. What would change on the map? 4. Imagine a core member leaving. What internal states would be at risk? 5. What does this map tell you about what holds your circle together?

Reflection Prompts

Write individually (or discuss aloud) after the activity: - What surprised you about the mapping exercise? - Did you discover internal states you had not consciously recognized before? - How does thinking about your circle as a "system" change how you understand its value or fragility?

Extension

Take a photo of your completed map. At next week's meeting, revisit it briefly. Has anything changed? Has a new external state entered through the boundary? This is the circle as a living system — always in motion, always maintaining itself.